efforts to strengthen national unity, sovereignty and integrity are often undermined by misrepresenting facts. Surprisingly, improvements in governance, applications of technology and progress on long-festering issues can be depicted as detrimental to freedom. Even prominent institutions indulge in disinformation in pursuit of a cause. History can be airbrushed and unfavourable events conveniently ignored. In our quest, we have discovered that political votebanks are a reality strongly beyond our shores as well. Robustly defending the nation against such undermining is a commitment that must be recognized.

If this was just a debate, perhaps that would matter less. But it is a harsh reality at work. Some of it may be ideological, but there is also the competitive nature of international relations. Bluntly put, there have always been interests that militate against a strong and united India. In the past, they exploited every faultline that our society provided: religion, language, ethnicity and social strata. Today, in a different garb and with new arguments, they are even more active than before. Perhaps, more of us need to ask ourselves why separatism in India finds regular support in quarters abroad. For that matter, how terrorism directed at us is consistently underplayed or even rationalized. Indeed, why some foreign forums lend themselves so readily to the denigration of our record and achievements. The task of foreign policy, when confronted with such calculations and stratagems, is to push back strongly even while advancing our own narrative.

ACCELERATING NATIONAL DEVELOPMENT

Since the drive for prosperity is a constant endeavour for all societies, it is natural that policymaking is also devoted to this goal. The most obvious expression of that is the promotion of trade and investments. Markets do not always work by themselves; in reality, pretty much everybody utilizes encouragement and facilitation. Those with historical handicaps have an even stronger reason to do so. We are still playing catch-up on industrialization, technology acquisition and competitiveness and will continue to do so for some time.

Just building capabilities at home, however, may not be adequate. Securing business abroad needs information, networking and access. There is a virtuous cycle at work here, whereby greater trade and economic